

RECONSTRUCTION

PEPLOS STYLE

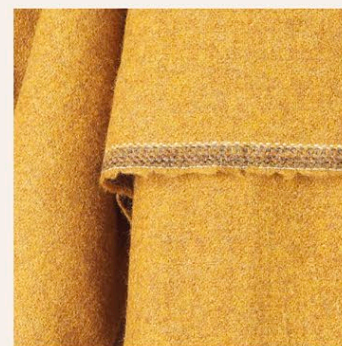
Combinations of wrapped dresses and sleeved linen shifts were worn from the Bronze Age (more than 4,000 years ago) and formed the basis of Ancient Greek and Roman women's wardrobes. An example of this dress style survives from a Danish "bog body" of around 500BCE, and the garments only appear to have gone out of fashion with the Northern European move to Christianity. The peplos-style dress is simply a large tube of cloth. The fold at the top controls the length in wear, and two brooches hold it in place at the shoulders.

IN DETAIL



◀ IRON-AGE REPLICAS

Bronze safety-pin brooches made from a single piece of coiled wire are used to fix the peplos at the shoulder. The changing style of brooches is revealed through finds in early Saxon graves and often give an indication of the wealth of the individual.



◀ WOVEN BORDERS

The wool fabric would have been woven on an upright loom, either warp weighted or with upper and lower beams. On these looms it was possible to weave the cloth either as a continuous tube or as a single large piece. The border design is part of the weave.

Brooches at each shoulder did not always match

Natural opening created for arms

Linen undershirt could be laundered

Garment falls in heavy folds

◀ WARMTH AND PROTECTION

As with the tunic, this garment is managed by the wearer and may be worn with a belt and shortened for practical work. The dense wool provides good protection and an extra peplos-style outer garment could be added in cold weather.



◀ DRESSING VENUS

Two attendants dress Venus, drawing her peplos up over a filmy shift in this detail of the birth of Venus from a marble relief on the Ludovisi Throne, c. 470–60BCE.